

Virtue Ethics and Modern Technology

Are Social Media and AI Making Us Stupider, Meaner, and Less Happy?

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PHIL 1150: Computing and AI Ethics

Central Questions

- What is virtue ethics, and how does Aristotle understand human character and flourishing?
- What makes technology a moral concern—not just a tool but a shaper of who we are becoming?
- How might social media and AI undermine intellectual virtues like curiosity and open-mindedness?
- How might digital environments erode moral virtues like empathy, patience, and honesty?
- Are virtue ethics arguments for technology regulation compatible with individual liberty?

Will Durant, summarizing Aristotle's Nicomachean Ethics (Aristotle, 2009)

“We are what we repeatedly do. Excellence, then, is not an act, but a habit.”
(Often misattributed to Aristotle himself—a nice lesson in checking sources!)

Lecture Outline

Introduction: Virtue Ethics and Technology

Intellectual Virtues Under Threat

Moral Virtues Under Threat

Eudaimonia Under Threat

Policy Responses

Objections and Responses

Connections to Previous Lectures

Lecture 1 (History): Every IT revolution changes not just what people do but how they think. Writing atrophied memory; mass media enabled propaganda. How might social media and AI reshape character at scale?

Looking ahead:

- **Lecture 3 (Free Speech):** If the self is shaped by online discourse, what follows for speech regulation?
- **Lectures 4–6 (IP, Crypto, Privacy):** Platform design choices affect users' character—who is responsible?
- **Lectures 7–8 (AI, Work):** AI systems that learn from human behavior may reinforce vices at scale.

Discussion

Which virtues or vices do you think social media most reliably cultivates?

Who Was Aristotle?

Life (384–322 BCE)

- Born in Stagira, northern Greece
- Studied at Plato's Academy for 20 years
- Tutor to Alexander the Great
- Founded his own school, the *Lyceum*

Revolutionary Thinker

- Focused on **observable nature**, not abstract forms
- Bridged theory and practice
- Founder of systematic logic

Why Aristotle?

- He asked: *What is human flourishing?*
- He connected virtue to **habit and practice**
- His ethics are **deeply practical**—about how we actually live
- He understood that our **character is shaped** by repeated actions

The Key Insight

Our character is not fixed. We *become* virtuous through practice.

Aristotle in Marble

The Philosopher (384–322 BCE)

- Studied at **Plato's Academy** for 20 years before founding his own school
- His **Lyceum** became one of the ancient world's great centers of learning
- Tutor to the young **Alexander the Great**
- Medieval scholars simply called him "**the Philosopher**"—no other name needed
- His *Nicomachean Ethics* remains foundational to moral philosophy

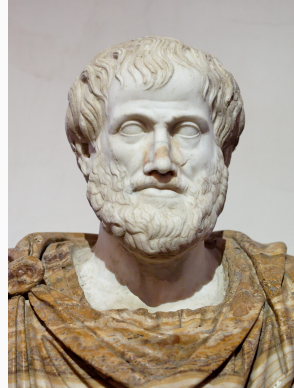
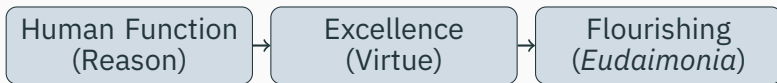


Figure 1: *

Aristotle, Roman marble copy of a Greek bronze by Lysippos, c. 330 BCE. Museo Nazionale Romano, Rome. Public domain.

Aristotle's Ethical Framework: The Big Picture

- Ethics as inquiry into the **good life** (not just right action)
- The **function argument** (*ergon*): What is the distinctive function of human beings?
- **Virtue** (*arête*) = excellence in performing our function
- Virtue leads to **flourishing** (*eudaimonia*)



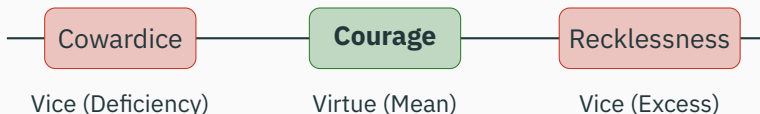
Eudaimonia Defined

- **Eudaimonia** = “flourishing,” “well-being,” “living well and doing well”
- *Not* “happiness” in the modern hedonic sense (feeling good)
- Activity of soul in accordance with virtue over a **complete life**

	Eudaimonia	Hedonic Happiness	Life Satisfaction
Focus	Living virtuously	Feeling pleasure	Judging life positively
Timeframe	Complete life	Momentary	Retrospective
Source	Virtuous activity	Pleasant experiences	Meeting expectations
Can be wrong?	No (constitutive)	Yes (can feel happy doing bad)	Yes (can be mistaken)

The Nature of Virtue (*Arête*)

- Virtues are stable **character traits** (*hexeis*)
- The **Doctrine of the Mean**: Virtue as balance between excess and deficiency
- Virtues are **acquired through practice** and habituation



Discussion

Can you identify the mean between “too much time spent online” and “too little”?

Intellectual vs. Moral Virtues

Intellectual Virtues

- **Sophia:** Theoretical wisdom
- **Phronesis:** Practical wisdom
- **Episteme:** Scientific knowledge
- **Nous:** Intuitive reason
- **Techne:** Craft/skill

Moral Virtues

- Courage
- Temperance
- Justice
- Generosity
- Honesty
- Friendliness

Key Insight

Phronesis (practical wisdom) is the “master virtue”—it tells us how to apply all the other virtues in particular situations.

The Role of Phronesis (Practical Wisdom)

Phronesis involves:

- **Perception of particulars:** Seeing what the situation requires
- **Deliberation:** Reasoning about means to good ends
- **Integration:** Balancing competing considerations
- **Judgment:** Knowing when and how to act



Why This Matters for AI

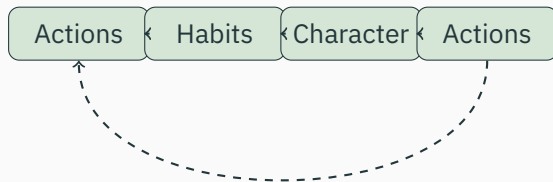
Phronesis *cannot be reduced to rules or algorithms*—it requires human judgment shaped by experience and character.

Habituation and Moral Development

Aristotle

“We become just by doing just acts, temperate by doing temperate acts, brave by doing brave acts.”

- Virtue requires **practice**—we learn by doing
- **Moral education** and environment matter enormously



Discussion

What character traits might daily social media use be cultivating in you?

Plato and Aristotle: The School of Athens

Raphael's Masterpiece (1509–1511)

- Painted for Pope Julius II's private library in the Vatican
- The great thinkers of antiquity gathered in an idealized Athens
- **Center:** Plato (pointing up—Ideal Forms) and Aristotle (hand level—observation)

The Contrast

Plato's ethics flows from ideal Forms; Aristotle's from observing how virtuous people actually live.



Figure 2: *

Raphael Sanzio, *The School of Athens*, 1509–1511.
Apostolic Palace, Vatican City. Public domain.

Modern Revival: Alasdair MacIntyre

After Virtue (MacIntyre, 1981): Diagnosis of moral fragmentation

- **Emotivism critique:** Modern ethics lacks a shared framework
- Moral language has become “masks for expressions of personal preference”
- Virtues require **social practices** and **traditions**
- We need **narrative unity**—understanding our lives as coherent stories

MacIntyre (MacIntyre, 1981)

“I can only answer the question ‘What am I to do?’ if I can answer the prior question ‘Of what story or stories do I find myself a part?’ ”

Discussion

Does social media help or hinder you in constructing a coherent life narrative?

Modern Revival: Rosalind Hursthouse

Virtue ethics *is* action-guiding!

- The **v-rules**: “Do what is honest,” “Don’t do what is cruel”
- Act as a **virtuous person** would act in the circumstances
- Virtue ethics handles **moral dilemmas** and “moral residue”

	Deontological Rules	V-Rules
Form	“Don’t lie”	“Be honest”
Focus	Prohibited actions	Character & motivation
Guidance	External constraints	Internal compass
Flexibility	Rigid application	Contextual wisdom

Modern Revival: Martha Nussbaum

Capabilities Approach: What must humans be able to do/be to flourish?

- Universal human **vulnerabilities and needs**
- Connects virtue ethics to **policy and social justice**

Nussbaum's Central Capabilities (Selected)

1. Life—living a life of normal length
2. Bodily health—nourishment, shelter
3. Senses, imagination, thought—education, free expression
4. Emotions—attachments to things and people
5. Practical reason—forming a conception of the good
6. Affiliation—living with others, self-respect
7. Play—recreational activities

Discussion

Which of these capabilities might technology enhance? Which might it diminish?

Technomoral Virtues for 21st-century flourishing:

- We habituate ourselves *through* our technological practices
- Technology can cultivate virtue *or* vice
- Need a new framework for the digital age

Vallor's Twelve Technomoral Virtues

- | | | |
|----------------|------------|-----------------------------|
| • Honesty | • Courage | • Flexibility |
| • Self-control | • Empathy | • Perspective |
| • Humility | • Care | • Magnanimity |
| • Justice | • Civility | • Technomoral Wisdom |

Lecture Outline

Introduction: Virtue Ethics and Technology

Intellectual Virtues Under Threat

Moral Virtues Under Threat

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Policy Responses

Objections and Responses

Intellectual Virtues at Stake

Key **intellectual virtues** under examination:

- **Curiosity:** Love of learning
- **Intellectual humility:** Recognizing limits
- **Love of truth:** Valuing accuracy over comfort
- **Open-mindedness:** Considering other views
- **Intellectual courage:** Following evidence
- **Intellectual autonomy:** Thinking for oneself

The Central Question

Are social media and AI systematically undermining our capacity to develop and exercise these virtues?

Argument 1: Technology and Intellectual Vice

The Argument in Standard Form

1. Intellectual virtues are cultivated through sustained, effortful cognitive practices (attention, memory, critical analysis, deep reading).
 2. Social media and AI systematically replace or undermine these practices.
 3. Habituation in intellectually passive behaviors cultivates intellectual vice, not virtue.
- C. Therefore, social media and AI tend to undermine intellectual virtue.**

Our task: Examine the evidence for each premise.

Premise 1: How Intellectual Virtues Are Cultivated

Intellectual virtue requires **effortful practice**:

- Develop **sustained attention** through deep reading and focused study
- Engage in **memory work** through effortful encoding and retrieval
- Practice **confronting difficulty** by struggling without immediate help
- Seek **diverse exposure** by encountering challenging viewpoints
- Cultivate **slow thinking** through deliberate reasoning over snap judgments

William James (James, 1890)

“The faculty of voluntarily bringing back a wandering attention, over and over again, is the very root of judgment, character, and will.”

Premise 2a: The Attention Crisis

Nicholas Carr, *The Shallows* (Carr, 2010) and **Jonathan Haidt** (Haidt, 2024):

- Internet use literally **rewires the brain** for distraction
- **Variable reward schedules** hijack dopamine systems
- “**Continuous partial attention**” replaces deep focus
- Estimates of daily phone checks vary widely across studies (~60–150+)—treat any precise number with caution

Metric	2004	2020s
Avg. time on one screen before switching	~2.5 minutes	~47 seconds

Table 1: Gloria Mark’s workplace-observation studies (*Attention Span*, 2023). Note: this measures **screen-switching**, not “attention span”—the headline version of this stat overstates the finding.

Discussion

When was the last time you read for 30+ minutes without checking your phone?

Premise 2b: Outsourcing Memory and Cognition

Cognitive offloading: Using technology as external memory

- The “**Google Effects on Memory**” (Sparrow et al., 2011) shows we remember *where* to find information rather than the information itself
- **GPS navigation** reduces spatial reasoning and mental mapping
- **AI writing tools** outsource composition and critical thinking
- **Calculators and now AI** deepen the deskilling concern beyond simple math

The Concern

If we don't *practice* remembering, analyzing, and reasoning, we don't develop the intellectual virtues that these activities cultivate.

Premise 2c: Epistemic Bubbles and Echo Chambers

C. Thi Nguyen's important distinction:

	Epistemic Bubble	Echo Chamber
Mechanism	Other voices not heard	Other voices actively discredited
Result	Missing information	Distrust of outside sources
Fix	Exposure to other views	Much harder—trust must be rebuilt

- **Algorithmic curation** creates bubbles by design
- Engagement-maximizing algorithms reward **confirmation bias**
- Undermines **intellectual humility** and **open-mindedness**

Discussion

How often do you seek out viewpoints that challenge your own beliefs?

Premise 2d: AI and Intellectual Dependency

Shannon Vallor on “moral deskilling” through automation:

- ChatGPT and the **outsourcing of thinking itself**
- Parallel to calculator debates—but *much deeper*
- We lose the **struggle** that builds intellectual virtue
- AI provides answers without cultivating **understanding**

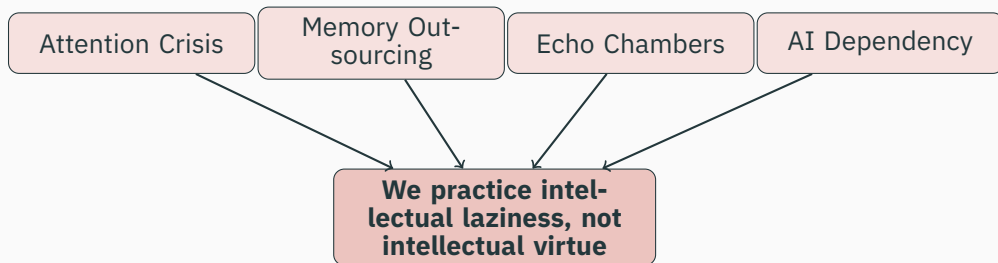
Vallor, Technology and the Virtues (Vallor, 2016)

“Technologies that remove the need for us to develop or exercise our own practical skills and judgment ... can weaken or even eliminate our opportunities to cultivate virtue.”

Discussion

When is it appropriate to use AI for help vs. when does it become intellectual “cheating”?

Synthesis: Intellectual Virtue Undermined



Connecting back to Aristotle: We become what we repeatedly do. If we repeatedly practice distraction, outsourcing, and intellectual passivity, we cultivate intellectual *vice*.

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Moral Virtues at Stake

Key **moral virtues** under examination:

- **Empathy:** Feeling with others
- **Compassion:** Caring about suffering
- **Patience:** Tolerating delay/difficulty
- **Temperance:** Self-control
- **Civility:** Respectful discourse
- **Honesty:** Truthfulness
- **Justice:** Fairness to others
- **Kindness:** Benevolence

The Central Question

Are social media and AI systematically undermining our capacity to develop and exercise these virtues?

Argument 2: Technology and Moral Vice

The Argument in Standard Form

1. Moral virtues are cultivated through embodied, face-to-face social practices involving vulnerability and reciprocity.
 2. Digital mediation systematically degrades or replaces these practices.
 3. Online environments actively habituate us toward moral vices (cruelty, impatience, dishonesty, outrage).
- C. Therefore, social media and AI tend to undermine moral virtue.**

Our task: Examine the evidence for each premise.

Premise 1: How Moral Virtues Are Cultivated

Sherry Turkle, *Reclaiming Conversation* (Turkle, 2015):

- **Face-to-face conversation** is the crucible of empathy
- We need **embodied presence**—eye contact, tone, physical co-presence
- Moral development requires **vulnerability and reciprocity**
- Learning to tolerate **boredom and discomfort** builds character

Turkle (Turkle, 2015)

“Face-to-face conversation is the most human—and humanizing—thing we do. Fully present to one another, we learn to listen. It’s where we develop the capacity for empathy.”

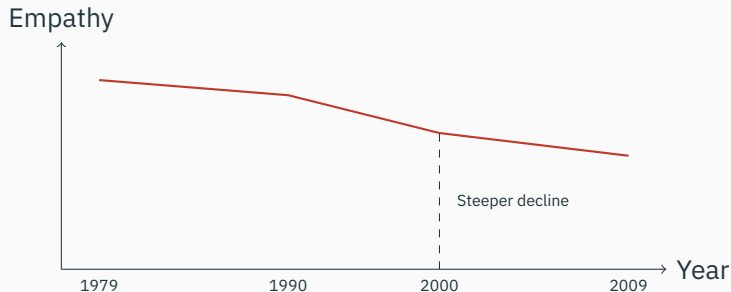
Discussion

Do you behave differently in text messages than in face-to-face conversation?
How?

Premise 2a: The Empathy Decline

University of Michigan meta-study (Konrath et al., 2011):

- **40% decline** in empathy among college students (1979–2009)
- Steepest decline after 2000—correlates with digital communication rise
- Teens spending less time in **face-to-face interaction**
- Empathy requires **practice**—and we're practicing less



Illustrative sketch of the trend reported by Konrath et al.—not plotted from the actual data.

Premise 2b: Online Disinhibition and Cruelty

John Suler's "Online Disinhibition Effect":

Factor	Effect on Behavior
Anonymity	"You don't know me"—reduced accountability
Invisibility	Can't see victim's pain—reduced empathy cues
Asynchronicity	No immediate feedback—say things you'd regret
Dissociative imagination	Online self feels separate from "real" self
Minimization of authority	Flattened hierarchies, less restraint

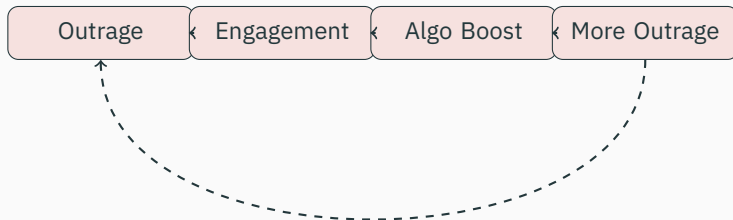
Discussion

The result is normalized cruelty—behavior unthinkable in person becomes routine online. Have you ever posted something you wouldn't say to someone's face?

Premise 2c: Outrage as Business Model

Jonathan Haidt on social media's transformation:

- **2009**: Facebook adds “Like”; Twitter adds “Retweet”
- **Outrage generates engagement**—anger spreads faster than joy
- **Moral grandstanding** rewarded over moral action
- **Tribal epistemology**: Demonization of the “other side”



Discussion

Have you ever shared something online primarily because it made you angry?

Premise 2d: Dishonesty and Performative Identity

Technology enables and encourages **inauthenticity**:

- **Curated self-presentation** creates a gap between Instagram and reality
- **Performative virtue** allows us to signal goodness without actually being good
- **Deepfakes and synthetic media** make truth increasingly optional
- **AI-generated content** erodes authentic human communication
- These combine to cause a **collapse of trust** in media, institutions, and each other

Hannah Arendt

“The ideal subject of totalitarian rule is not the convinced Nazi or the convinced Communist, but people for whom the distinction between fact and fiction ... no longer exists.”

Synthesis: Moral Virtue Undermined

Virtue	Traditional Practice	Digital Replacement
Empathy	Face-to-face conversation	Text-based interaction
Patience	Waiting, delayed gratification	Instant everything
Civility	Social norms, accountability	Anonymous cruelty
Honesty	Reputation, trust-building	Curated personas
Temperance	Natural limits	Infinite scroll, autoplay

The Habituation Problem

We are practicing outrage instead of empathy, cruelty instead of kindness, performance instead of authenticity. **We become what we practice.**

Discussion

What emotions does your social media feed most often evoke in you?

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Eudaimonia Under Threat

Beyond individual virtues: the **whole flourishing life**

- Eudaimonia requires **integrated exercise of virtue** across a complete life
- It requires **meaningful relationships**, not just connections
- It requires **purposeful activity**, not just consumption
- It requires **self-knowledge**, not algorithmic identity

Important Note

“Happiness” here means *eudaimonia*—not just feeling good, but genuinely flourishing as a human being.

Argument 3: Technology and Diminished Flourishing

The Argument in Standard Form

1. Eudaimonia requires integrated exercise of virtue across a complete life, including meaningful relationships, purposeful activity, and self-knowledge.
2. Social media and AI fragment attention, commodify relationships, and distort self-understanding.
3. These effects directly impede the conditions necessary for eudaimonia.

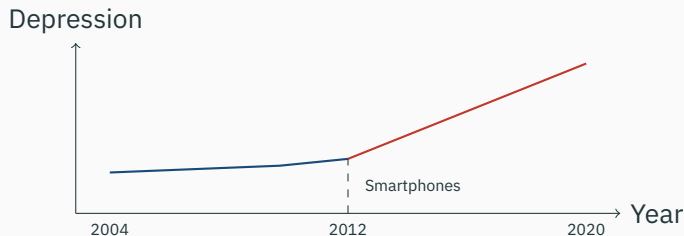
C. Therefore, social media and AI tend to undermine human flourishing.

Our task: Examine the evidence for each premise.

Premise 2a: The Mental Health Crisis

Jonathan Haidt, *The Anxious Generation* (Haidt, 2024):

- Teen depression and anxiety **spiked after 2012** (smartphone majority)
- “**Compare and despair**”: Social comparison on steroids
- **Sleep deprivation**: Phones in bedrooms
- Girls especially affected (social comparison + relational aggression)



Illustrative sketch of the pattern Haidt describes—not plotted from the actual data.

Discussion

Have you noticed changes in your own or peers' mental health related to tech use?

But Is It Causal? The Haidt Debate

The Skeptics' Critique (Candice Odgers; Orben & Przybylski)

- The evidence is largely **correlational**—and the correlations are small
- One large-dataset analysis: social media explained less variance in teen well-being than **eating potatoes** or **wearing glasses**
- **Reverse causation** is plausible: struggling teens may turn to social media
- Rival explanations for the post-2012 rise: economic anxiety, academic pressure, better screening and reporting

Haidt's reply: deactivation *experiments* show effects too, and the timing replicates across many countries at once.

The Methodological Lesson

A **live scientific debate**, not settled fact—hold the hypothesis seriously, but provisionally.

Premise 2b: Commodification of Relationships

Turkle: “Alone Together”

- **Friendship as metric:** Followers, likes, streaks
- **Dating apps:** Optimization and commodification of romance
- Loss of **serendipity** and organic connection
- **Parasocial relationships:** One-sided bonds with influencers/AI
- The **loneliness epidemic:** More “connected” than ever, more alone

Turkle (Turkle, 2011)

“We expect more from technology and less from each other.”

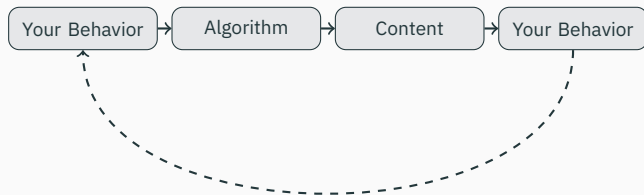
Discussion

How many of your online “friends” would you call in a genuine crisis?

Premise 2c: Distorted Self-Understanding

Algorithmic identity: You are what the algorithm thinks you are

- **Filter bubbles** as distorting mirrors
- The algorithm shows “more of what you’ll predictably attend to”—but is that *you*?
- It **shapes your behavior** to maximize engagement—which may not align with your flourishing



Discussion

Does your “For You” page reflect who you really are—or who the algorithm wants you to be?

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From Diagnosis to Policy

If the virtue ethics diagnosis is correct, what follows?

- **Individual responses:** Digital detox, mindfulness, intentional use
- **Structural responses:** Regulation, design mandates, education
- Virtue ethics case for regulation: Creating environments **conducive to flourishing**

	Individual	Structural
Advantages	Personal agency, immediate	Addresses root causes
Limits	Willpower exhaustion, inequality	Paternalism concerns
Examples	Phone-free meals	Age restrictions

Discussion

Is changing individual behavior enough, or do we need systemic/policy changes?

Australia's Social Media Minimum Age Law (2024)

Minimum age of **16** for social media accounts; platforms face fines for non-compliance. Implemented 2025.

Policy Type	Virtue Ethics Rationale
Age restrictions	Protect developing capacity for virtue
Design mandates	Remove features that habituate vice
Algorithm transparency	Enable informed choice
Digital literacy education	Cultivate technomoral wisdom
AI governance	Preserve authentic human connection

Discussion

Should governments regulate social media to protect flourishing, or is this over-reach?

Vallor's Vision: Cultivating Technomoral Wisdom

Technology as **pharmakon** (Greek: both poison and cure):

- Technology can cultivate virtue *or* vice—depends on design and use
- Need **intentional design** for virtue cultivation
- Need **individual practices** that build character

Practical Recommendations

- **Digital sabbaths**: Regular disconnection for reflection
- **Attention training**: Meditation, deep reading practices
- **Face-to-face priority**: Protect in-person relationships
- **Critical consumption**: Question algorithmic recommendations
- **Moral “operating systems”**: Explicit frameworks for tech use

Discussion

Which of these recommendations could you realistically implement this week?

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Objection 1: The Positive Liberty Problem

Berlin/Mill: The Paternalism Worry

1. Virtue ethics assumes a **particular conception of the good life**.
 2. In a pluralistic society, the state should not impose any conception of the good (**negative liberty**).
 3. Restricting social media treats citizens as children unable to choose their own good.
- C.** This is **paternalistic overreach** that threatens individual liberty.

Isaiah Berlin, “Two Concepts of Liberty”

“Positive liberty”—the freedom *to* flourish—has historically justified tyranny in the name of people’s “true” interests.

Responses to the Liberty Objection

1. **Children vs. adults:** Age-based restrictions less controversial
2. **Addiction and autonomy:** Can you freely choose what undermines your capacity to choose?
3. **Market failures:** “Choice architecture” already manipulated by corporations seeking profit
4. **Harm to others:** Externalities of social media on democratic discourse
5. **Soft vs. hard paternalism:** Nudges and defaults vs. outright bans

Key Question

Is it “freedom” to be manipulated by algorithms designed to maximize engagement at the expense of your wellbeing?

Objection 2: The Nietzschean Worry

Nietzsche: Who Decides What Virtue Is?

1. Virtue ethics assumes we can reliably identify virtue vs. vice.
 2. But historical “virtues” often reflected **power structures** or “**herd mentality**.”
 3. Some “vices” (pride, aggression) may be **necessary for excellence**.
- C.** The virtue critique of technology may reflect **conservative bias**.

Nietzsche, Beyond Good and Evil

“What is called virtue in the herd-man would be vice for the higher man. ... The virtues of the common man would perhaps signify vices and weaknesses in a philosopher.”

Discussion

Could “doom-scrolling” ever be reframed as a virtue? What would that require?

Key Concepts i

Aristotle (384–322 BCE) argued that character is formed through *habituation*—repeated practice that makes a disposition stable. The ethical question is not just what we do once, but what we do repeatedly.

Eudaimonia is Aristotle's term for human flourishing—not pleasure, but the active exercise of one's highest capacities in a complete and characterful life.

Virtue / arete is a stable disposition to act, feel, and perceive in the right way; **vice** is its opposite. Both are cultivated—or corrupted—by the environments we inhabit, including digital ones.

Shannon Vallor applies Aristotle to technology, arguing that social media and AI can habituate users into intellectual and moral vices that undermine flourishing.

Negative liberty (Isaiah Berlin) is freedom *from* interference; **positive liberty** is freedom *to* flourish. The key objection to virtue-ethics regulation is that positive liberty arguments have historically justified paternalism and tyranny.

Nietzsche 's challenge: who decides what counts as virtue? Historical “virtues” often reflected power structures; calling doom-scrolling a vice may simply reflect conservative bias.

Discussion

What practices in your own technological life cultivate virtue? Which cultivate vice?